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COL-313901

Laplace Scientific Computing Center

Laplace Researcher I: Welcome to the LSCC headquarters.

Laplace Researcher I: I see you were brought in from one of our partner labs. It won't take long for you to notice we do things differently around here.

Laplace Researcher I: Rule one at Laplace is don't make trouble. The second rule is if you really have to make trouble, make it spectacular.

New Researcher: Thank you for the warning, but I'm sure you needn't worry.

Laplace Researcher I: I don't think you understand just what you're in for yet. Ah, third rule: never, under any circumstances, get on the wrong side of Medicine Pocket. Here we are.

The two of them stand before a door ravaged by bite marks. A crooked sheet of paper is taped to it, the title aggressively outlined in colored marker.

New Researcher: "Join us! The Pre-Storm Atmospheric and Oceanic Circulation Survey Group is now recruiting new members!"

New Researcher: It's a compelling research topic. Though it's a little strange to see it written out in such a childish way.

Laplace Researcher I: Oh, don't mind the door. It's only the unfortunate aftermath of a disgruntled researcher. Allow me to remind you of Rule Three. Repairs will be ordered as soon as the budget permits; should be around 178 business days, give or take.

Laplace Researcher I: Ah! Damn it! What kind of monster electrifies a doorknob?! Electrocuting someone doesn't mean you inherit their funding, Medicine Pocket!

Laplace Researcher I: Anyway, this is your new workspace.

At that, the researcher's voice pauses for a moment.

Laplace Researcher I: That's weird. I could've sworn I heard Ms. Simone's voice just now.

Laplace Researcher I: Don't tell me she's come to shut the circulation survey group down once and for all.

Observation Room

Inside the observation room, the assistant stands before the circulation survey group's only two members.

Rachel: Which is it? Good news, bad news, or something in between?

Marguerite: Tous les mêmes. Just let Ms. Simone speak.

Marguerite: I'm sure she'll tell us whatever the case may be.

It's a tepid attempt at calming her colleague, and it predictably falls flat.

Rachel: I know. It's either spectacularly good news or catastrophically bad news. There's no middle ground.

Assistant Simone: Rachel, Marguerite, I have good news.

Assistant Simone: The Pre-Storm Atmospheric and Oceanic Circulation Survey Group's field research proposal has been approved.

Marguerite: That is excellent.

Marguerite: We can finally begin preparations for our first field study.

But her colleague seems hung up on something entirely different.

Rachel: You know, you're the third person to ever say our project's entire name correctly. Does that mean Laplace is finally going to give us the attention we deserve? Dare I dream that you might even increase our budget?

Assistant Simone: Uhm, I'm afraid not.

Rachel: Fine, fine, but at least tell me that all those pamphlets I sent out paid off! I even mailed copies to all our partner labs.

Assistant Simone: Putting you a hair's breadth away from violating the "Storm" confidentiality agreement. You should know better than to reveal that kind of sensitive information without approval.

Assistant Simone: Nevertheless, they did achieve their intended effect.

Rachel: Huh? Really, what do you mean?

Assistant Simone: We've received a transfer application from a researcher at the South Wales Meteorological Centre. She's expressed interest in joining the circulation survey group.

Assistant Simone: Marguerite, you might be familiar with her. She attended Cambridge around the same time you did.

Marguerite: Is that so?

Marguerite: Well, it's a big university, but who knows, it could be nice to see a familiar face.

The mild-mannered researcher wears her usual smile, though her actual emotions beneath are harder to read.

Marguerite: Come in.

New Researcher: The Pre-Storm Atmospheric and Oceanic Circulation Survey Group. Is this the right place?

Rachel: Absolutely! And you're now the fourth person to ever get our full name right!

Marguerite: Welcome to the team. The enthusiastic one is our group leader, Rachel, and I'm—

The newcomer's eyes swivel to the ash-blond researcher and then hold a long stare.

A brief silence follows.

New Researcher: Marguerite, it's been a long time.

Coalwall: You might not remember my name. Call me Coalwall.

Assistant Simone: Please, have a seat. I'll outline the specifics.

Assistant Simone: Although your field expedition has been approved, we believe your safety protocols require further revision.

Assistant Simone: For example, your evacuation has to be set eight hours before the "Storm" countdown ends; we can't justify leaving it any closer.

Rachel: But the Timekeeper's "Storm" warning only gives us 24 hours. That won't give us much time to observe the "Storm's" effects.

Rachel: Could do one hour instead. Two maybe?

Assistant Simone: Researcher safety must be placed above all else. This new requirement comes directly from the Staff Committee. We cannot afford to lose any more of our people to the "Storm."

Marguerite: The Staff Committee's concerns are justified. The current evacuation plan does have us leaving with very little time to spare.

Assistant Simone: I understand your desire to have as much observational data as possible, Researcher Rachel. But we can't afford to put you in danger.

Assistant Simone: Marguerite, I trust you to show more patience in this matter. I hope you might be able to guide our colleague here to a more reasonable conclusion.

Marguerite: I'll do my best.

Marguerite: I may not have the same sudden flashes of brilliance my colleagues do, but you know my documentation is always meticulous.

A perfectly measured hint of embarrassment crosses her face.

Assistant Simone: There aren't many researchers left at the LSCC approaching the "Storm," from the perspective of natural phenomena. One of them has been locked up in his laboratory since the first "Storm," with only a bottle for company.

Assistant Simone: While I'm sure neither of you wants to end up in the same position, that doesn't mean you can or should expect accommodation in every matter, especially when it comes to safety.

A brilliant physicist's entire world undone by the "Storm" is hardly an unusual tale.

Marguerite: I understand, Ms. Simone.

Coalwall: Perhaps I might be able to assist? I wrote more than a few safety manuals for my old laboratory.

Assistant Simone: Thank you, everyone.

Assistant Simone: Now, Rachel, I need you to accompany me to collect some manuals and documentation for your new colleague. Are you free right now?

Rachel: I still have some meteorological data to—

Marguerite: We can organize that data for you. I'm sure Ms. Coalwall could use a good introductory assignment.

Assistant Simone: In that case, let's get going.

Rachel: I won't be long!

Marguerite: No need to rush back.

A single door separates noise from silence.

Marguerite gathers the scattered drafts on the desk while the new researcher watches.

Coalwall: You've changed.

Marguerite: Have I?

She casts a light and fleeting glance toward the quiet newcomer before her.

Coalwall: "Unremarkable at best. No significant achievements. We sometimes forget she's even there." That's what they say about you, you know?

Coalwall: Gentle. Meek. Harmlessly ineffectual.

Coalwall: Sounds nothing like the woman I knew from Cambridge.

Marguerite turns. She holds a smile in an exact curve, like a mask welded in place, provoking a sharp reaction from Coalwall.

Marguerite: I see. Well, it isn't the worst assessment.

Marguerite: I'm surprised you still remember me.

Marguerite: But I'm glad to see you here all the same. Nice to know a fellow alumna also made it through the "Storm."

Coalwall: Spare me the pleasantries. We weren't close, and this isn't some long-awaited reunion.

Marguerite: I apologize. If you're not in the mood for small talk, then what would you like to discuss?

Her frozen smile remains unwavering.

Coalwall: You remember Annie, don't you?

Coalwall: From Professor Ludwig's class, you remember, don't you? She followed you around like a shadow for a long while. She worked with you on that meteorological projection study.

Coalwall: And then one day, they found her dead on a footpath. Her collar was covered with dew.

Marguerite: Why bring up something awful like that?

Marguerite: As I recall, you and Annie were not particularly close.

Coalwall: No. We weren't close.

A faint, concealed sorrow passes across the researcher's face.

Coalwall: But, Marguerite, I need to know: what really happened to Annie?

[English text unavailable]

COL-313902

Cambridge University

Cambridge University, 1987.

A cold, damp wind brushes the treetops. At the lectern, Professor Ludwig pauses, momentarily distracted by the rustling.

Ludwig: In short, even a system ruled by fixed equations can produce outcomes that appear entirely chaotic.

Ludwig: It feels like reading *The Phenomenology of Spirit*, precision so dense it leaves you lightheaded.

Ludwig: To be clear, I am not assigning you any additional philosophy reading. That will be all for today.

The class disperses. As he collects his papers, he observes a small cluster of students lingering.

Ludwig: Marguerite.

Marguerite: Professor Thoth.

Ludwig: Thoth? What an absurdity. I don't even look like an ibis.

Ludwig: Humorous nicknames aside. I'm curious: It's been a while since you transferred to my class. How are you adjusting?

Marguerite: Everything's going well, thanks to you. As for my coursework, I believe my research reports speak for themselves.

The student before him explains with an air of nonchalance.

Ludwig: Yes. *On the Atmospheric Neutrino Anomaly and Its Implications for Oscillation Models*. An excellent paper, indeed, indeed.

Ludwig: Objectively speaking, it is somewhat ahead of its time. Still, physics ought not regress simply because the era lags behind.

Ludwig: It appears you've adapted not only academically but to this era as well. My concern was unnecessary.

Marguerite: "This era" ...

She turns the unexpected phrase over in her mind.

Marguerite: Oh, you haven't forgotten what happened in 1999.

Marguerite: "To teach philosophy is the most absurd profession in the world?"

Ludwig: That is precisely why I stand here today, in the capacity of a visiting physics lecturer.

Ludwig: Cambridge has taken an interest in the research underway at Laplace's Plesetsk Branch and extended an invitation for me to teach when time permits.

Ludwig: The events of 1999 cut short my appointment, and with it, my chance to sponsor you.

Ludwig: I am pleased to see you also survived the "Storm."

Marguerite: You're not curious to know how I survived?

Ludwig: Would such knowledge alter your academic progress?

Marguerite: Hah, of course not.

Ludwig: Then it's none of my concern.

Ludwig: There's a lecture on aerospace experiments at the orbital station next week. You're welcome to sit in.

Marguerite: Thank you for the invitation, Professor Thoth.

Ludwig: Ah, your unique humor strikes again, Marguerite.

Ludwig: Three o'clock. Thursday.

Once assured she has noted the details, the avian professor inclines his head courteously and departs.

Marguerite: Goodbye, Professor Ludwig.

Marguerite: For such a grand enigma, I do hope your every appearance brings a new puzzle with it.

Marguerite: Things would be rather dull otherwise.

The transfer student looks over the equations and notes left on the board with a vacant expression.

Marguerite: Did you need something?

Marguerite: You've been eavesdropping back there for a while now.

A figure rises from her seat, visibly flustered.

???: I'm sorry. I didn't mean to. I was only—

Annie: I'm Annie.

Annie: You're Marguerite, aren't you? The one who wrote *On the Atmospheric Neutrino Anomaly and Its Implications for Oscillation Models*.

Marguerite looks up and studies the girl addressing her.

In an instant, she gathers what she needs: background, age, circumstances, temperament.

Gentle, timid, and in all respects a model student. Excessively empathetic, poor personal boundaries, a comfortable but ignoble upbringing, socially isolated due to her family's scandalous greed ... These traits combine to form the girl standing in front of her.

And she is not having an easy time with life here.

Annie: They all say you're a genius. You transferred in without any prior studies and still managed to write a paper like that.

Annie: I-I read your report. It was incredible. I really admire you.

Marguerite: There's no shortage of genius in this place.

The transfer student glances at the notebook on the desk. Her intention is not difficult to discern.

A fine leather cover. Meticulous notes. At the bottom: Thursday. Three o'clock.

She says nothing, simply waiting for the girl to finish her performance.

Annie: About the lecture Professor Ludwig mentioned, if it's all right, could I go with you?

Annie: Some of the third-year students said there may be paired work involved.

Annie: Marguerite, I'd like to ask you to go with me.

A tentative, unpracticed smile appears on her mask-like face.

Marguerite: Another unexpected development. I accept.

Marguerite: Annie ...

Marguerite: Annie, Annie, Annie ...

When she returns to herself, the honey-sweet name has already rolled off her tongue.

Marguerite: She was an interesting girl. A sweet girl.

Coalwall: What?

Marguerite: If you truly followed the matter, then you know the police concluded Annie's death was an accident. She had a congenital heart condition. Tragic, but nothing more.

Marguerite: Don't misunderstand me. I won't pretend to be oblivious to what you're implying. But I am curious what you're basing this thinly veiled accusation on.

Marguerite: You don't strike me as a researcher who speculates without evidence.

Coalwall: ...

Coalwall studies her new colleague's stoic and composed face.

Marguerite: What's troubling you? This is the Laplace Scientific Computing Center.

Marguerite: We're in a safe environment. If something is weighing on you, speak it openly so we can resolve any misunderstanding you might have on the matter.

Coalwall: Once, after class, I noticed an equation you left on the board.

Coalwall: It had nothing to do with the lecture, and it was no ordinary formula.

Coalwall: You wrote it boldly across the center of the board, where everyone could see it.

Coalwall: As though you were waiting for someone to notice it.

Marguerite: Oh? And what equation was that?

She briskly flips her ash-blonde hair back over her ear as if to encourage Coalwall to continue.

Coalwall: I think it was a model for predicting human behavior.

Coalwall: Not just any human. Someone you knew well, a particular individual.

Coalwall: I think it was for Annie.

Coalwall: You were organizing her movements, her decisions, her emotions, her very being, into an iterative mathematical formula.

Coalwall: And worse, your equations were complete. They were simple, simple enough for someone like me to understand.

Coalwall: What were you intending to do with it?

Marguerite feigns an expression between interest and bewilderment.

Marguerite: You're suggesting that I modeled an entire person into a single mathematical formula?

Marguerite: An intriguing and rather original hypothesis, Researcher Coalwall.

Coalwall: Don't patronize me, Marguerite.

Marguerite: Very well. My apologies.

Marguerite: If you truly believe there was some hidden motive or culprit behind Annie's accident—

Marguerite stops herself. She reaches among the folders and papers, withdrawing a notebook before handing it over to Coalwall.

The leather is elegant but aged, the paper tinted yellow with time.

Something stirs in Coalwall as she takes the notebook and opens it.

Coalwall: This is ...

Neat handwriting. Structured lecture notes.

Orbital station. Three o'clock. Thursday.

Coalwall: This is Annie's notebook.

Coalwall: I don't understand. Why do you have this?

Marguerite: This morning, I saw a dispatch list on Simone's desk.

Marguerite: The pen name "Coalwall" appeared frequently in Cambridge's student papers.

Coalwall: You predicted all of this from the beginning.

Marguerite: And this is the clue you were looking for.

Coalwall hesitates, but the temptation of the truth is too strong to rest on pride. She takes the notebook and leaves.

With Coalwall gone and the room empty, Marguerite slides her empty teacup forward.

A silver kettle descends from the chandelier, tilts slightly, and pours tea neatly into the cup.

X: Another pin-pointedly accurate prediction?

X: I actually put a surprising amount of thought into choosing between the chandelier-mounted kettle release system and the breadcrumb-launching file apparatus.

The kettle isn't the only thing that descends from above. Soon enough, her hidden colleague lowers himself as well.

Lorentz Butterfly: I do hope the next "accident" proves more interesting.

X: Whatever you need, just let me know.

X: On that topic, is there any dimension of your current research that might benefit from my assistance?

Lorentz Butterfly: Xavier, you're clearly not here out of concern for my research.

X: Xavier? That name belongs to a stray Eagle rescued from some long-obliterated ruins.

Lorentz Butterfly: And? It's likely vanished into the "Storm" by now. Consider the name yours now, Xavier.

X: Fine, have it your way. Speaking of Eagle, I meant to check how our eager scout has been doing as your assistant.

X: I mean, I was the one that recommended her in the first place. It'd be a real disappointment if she turned out to cause you any trouble.

Lorentz Butterfly: Objectively speaking, she's a good kid and a competent assistant.

Lorentz Butterfly: If I didn't know that you only handed her over to me because you were too lazy to teach her properly, your concern might come across more believable.

X: You are well aware that my pedagogical contributions trend toward the spectacularly impractical.

The two Institutum infiltrators exchange a knowing glance, silently abandoning the subject.

X: I noticed you've been unusually invested in this circulation group, so I came to spectate the proceedings for myself.

X: You're just looking for a little amusement, aren't you?

Lorentz Butterfly: And your chandelier kettle and breadcrumb-launching file apparatus don't qualify as amusement?

X: Our definitions are evidently divergent.

X: Go ahead and keep playing with your boring circulation team, but when you're free, come help me test my jet-powered inverted glider.

Lorentz Butterfly: I intend to be occupied for the foreseeable future.

[English text unavailable]

COL-313903

Hallway, Cambridge University

Annie: Marguerite! Marguerite!

The shouts draw nearer, accompanied by rapid footsteps.

Marguerite: Is something the matter?

Annie: You left so quickly after class. I've been chasing you halfway across campus.

Annie: I just wanted to say this is amazing! Our project got the highest mark in the class! I know it's mostly because of you.

Marguerite: No. The credit belongs to you, Annie.

Marguerite: You designed the proposal and handled the data analysis. I merely organized the results.

The indifferent transfer student observes the girl with clinical focus.

She calibrates the muscles of her own face accordingly.

At last, she produces a smile identical to Annie's. A flawless imitation.

Annie: You're smiling, Marguerite. I haven't seen you smile like that before.

Marguerite: Why wouldn't I smile? I'm thrilled.

Marguerite: There's really so much that I can learn from you.

Annie: Me? What could you possibly learn from me?

Marguerite: You possess a certain gentleness.

An overabundance of empathy.

Marguerite: And such selflessness.

A kindness indiscriminate in its application.

Marguerite: You think about others constantly.

And therefore, easily overlooked and undervalued.

Marguerite: I've learned a great deal from our time together.

Marguerite: I've reached a conclusion: I intend to integrate into this university environment the way you do.

Annie: That was surprisingly direct.

Annie: To tell the truth, you're the first real friend I've made here.

Annie: Thank you. Thank you, Marguerite.

Rachel: Thank you, Marguerite!!!

Rachel: It's only been a month since we were approved, and we've already finished our updated fieldwork proposal.

Marguerite: Coalwall stayed up all night refining the first draft of the safety regulations.

Marguerite: Her caution and precision are the real reasons we finally passed review. Thanks to that meticulous framework, we can now set our evacuation to just ninety minutes before the "Storm."

Rachel: Oh, of course, she deserves equal credit. I should formally thank both of you!

Coalwall: You're far too kind.

Coalwall: I'm just as interested as you are to see where this research leads.

Coalwall: There are so few projects here at Laplace that have nothing to do with arcanum.

Within the genuine warmth of this interaction, the pale researcher blends in without the slightest awkwardness.

Marguerite: After the "Storm," most purely scientific teams disbanded. Rachel here might be the last researcher that has maintained a strictly materialist analysis of the phenomenon.

Marguerite: Most have already given up, as a physical explanation seemed impossible.

Rachel: Well, I'm glad to know there's at least someone who appreciates my vision.

Marguerite: Every hypothesis has its reason for existing, and if it bears the slightest chance of being true, it's worth testing.

Marguerite: Newton and his apple began their journey with a flash of insight. Well, perhaps several.

Marguerite: From watching an apple fall to deriving the law of universal gravitation, then reconstructing it under general relativity.

Rachel: Exactly. Proving that science can still explain the post-"Storm" world is my top priority.

Marguerite: Do you feel the same, Researcher Coalwall? A desire to use scientific order to understand apparent chaos?

Her near-perfect imitation of a gentle look sends shivers down Coalwall's spine.

Coalwall: Oh, you shouldn't ask me. My opinion isn't really relevant.

Coalwall: All theoretical research, to me, is just speculation from an ivory tower. I prefer more practical work.

A sudden chill falls over their conversation.

For a moment, only the scratch of pens and the tapping of keys remain.

Rachel: Ah!

Rachel jumps to her feet and pulls the beeping communicator from the top shelf.

Marguerite: This is ...

Marguerite: The Timekeeper just issued the 24-hour countdown to the "Storm."

Marguerite: This is our golden opportunity to observe circulation changes prior to the "Storm."

[English text unavailable]

COL-313904

Temporary Station, Coral Islands

Rachel: Final equipment check.

Rachel: Huh? Why won't this component fit right?

A pair of warm, dry hands settles over Rachel's trembling shoulders.

Marguerite: I'll take care of it.

Marguerite: It was sooner than we expected, but everything is proceeding according to plan.

Rachel: I'm just nervous.

Rachel: We don't know what changes the "Storm" might bring in the future. Every occurrence is a rare and unique opportunity.

She takes a deep breath, forcing her hands to steady.

Coalwall: Our equipment here is woefully inadequate.

Coalwall: Look at these anemometer cups. Some of them are broken.

Marguerite: The field application's approval came on short notice. We've improved as much as we could within our time and budget.

Marguerite: And we've done it all in a month on a remote coral island in the middle of nowhere—the only place they'd let us try.

Rachel: The Foundation's local branch had to source this equipment from civilian suppliers. These things are so out of date we might as well be using coconuts, but we're intelligent, resourceful women. We've got this!

Coalwall: All right. Now before we set out, I stuffed a handful of compressed biscuits into my pockets and brought a thermos of hot water for tea.

Coalwall: The water's still hot.

Coalwall: So, even if we fail to gather any useful observations, at least we won't starve.

Rachel: Excellent. Researcher Coalwall has already taken care of our basic survival needs.

Rachel: At least we have a functional measuring apparatus. As long as this round of data can prove our hypothesis, we'll undoubtedly be able to apply for a thorough follow-up experiment.

Coalwall: And while you two deploy the probe out at sea, I'll set up our trade winds and atmospheric pressure monitoring stations.

Rachel: By yourself? That's a long trip up. You know, we could—

Coalwall: I work more efficiently alone.

She says with such complete certainty that there seems to be no question as she turns and walks out alone.

Sea, Near the Coral Islands

Rachel: Grab the buoy.

Rachel: How's it going? Can you manage things? Do you need my help?

Marguerite: You don't need to worry. I've got things under control.

Marguerite: You know, Rachel, I've noticed you're unusually tense.

Rachel: Can you blame me? I've been waiting for this moment for a very long time.

Rachel: We've successfully deployed the deep-water apparatus. But honestly, I'm more worried about Coalwall working alone.

Marguerite: I'd say she's proven reliable, even just in the short time we've worked together.

Rachel: You may be right.

Rachel: Still, have you noticed that she's quite harsh whenever she speaks to you?

Marguerite: Not especially, no. She has her own kind of way of speaking.

Rachel: She definitely comes across quite blunt at times. I think that's just the way she is.

Rachel: Even so, I can't shake the feeling that she's especially frosty around you. Am I just imagining things?

Marguerite: Hmm ...

Marguerite returns to her work without giving an immediate answer.

Marguerite: A mutual friend of ours from Cambridge died in an accident. For whatever reason, Coalwall has always thought I was responsible in some way.

Rachel: How could she possibly think you had anything to do with something like that?!

Rachel: But that does explain something. I saw Coalwall speaking with the cryptography lead. Y'know that fishbowl-headed Awakened?

Rachel: She seemed like she was asking for his help with some equations, maybe decrypting them. Then there's that black leather notebook she's always brooding over at night.

Marguerite: I think she means well; she's just trying to verify things for herself.

Rachel: Marguerite, I would hope that we can trust one another after all this time.

Rachel: No matter what, I'll stand by you.

Rachel: But I don't want you getting caught up in anything dangerous.

The water ripples. Their boat lies crosswise on the sea, dividing light from shadow.

Without changing her expression, Marguerite drops the buoy into the water, catching a fragment of memory in the dispersing rings.

Ludwig: Come in.

Office, Cambridge University

She steps into the office but does not fully close the door behind her.

Ludwig: Please, have a seat.

Marguerite: That won't be necessary. Professor Ludwig, may I ask why you wished to see me?

Marguerite: I understand your visiting lectureship has concluded. You came all the way from Plesetsk to Cambridge. I assume you have something "important" to inform me of.

The impatience and emphasis in her words fail to reach the other side of the desk.

The raven professor does not answer right away, weighing his choice of words.

Ludwig: ...

Ludwig: Marguerite, how have you been adjusting lately?

Marguerite: This isn't the first time you've asked that question, Professor.

Ludwig: It's not such a terrible opening line, is it now? After all, people and circumstances can change when least expected.

Ludwig: For instance, have you encountered any problems with your peers?

Ludwig: Perhaps I could offer you some assistance.

Exactly the sort of question guaranteed to irritate her.

Marguerite: Professor, what exactly are you trying to imply?

Marguerite: If you're only extending a courtesy, I have no need for it.

Ludwig: Then let us dispense with them.

Ludwig: Several days ago, at Foundation headquarters, I came across a newly issued warrant from Zeno.

Ludwig: An accused deserter whose description seemed oddly familiar to me.

Marguerite: I'm sure it's only a misunderstanding.

Ludwig: Perhaps, or it may be that you have your own way of dealing with the matter. I don't intend to probe any deeper.

Ludwig: I only hope none of this will affect your future studies. You are a natural-born researcher, Marguerite.

The conversation lapses into a poignant silence, the meaning of the words understated but clear between the two soft-spoken figures.

Marguerite: Because of the "Storm"?

Ludwig: Because of the "Storm."

Ludwig: I know of a place where you would be exempt from Zeno's scrutiny.

Ludwig: Would you be interested in joining the Laplace Scientific Computing Center?

As Marguerite leaves the office, she encounters an eavesdropper around the corner. She feigns surprise, although it is anything but.

The girl seizes her sleeve anxiously.

Marguerite: What is it, Annie? What are you doing here?

Annie: What did Professor Ludwig mean just now? Are you in some kind of danger?

Annie: You're not leaving Cambridge, are you?

The half-closed door served its intended purpose, just as predicted.

Marguerite: Did you hear all of that?

Annie: I ... I was just coming to find you. They told me you'd been called to the professor's office.

Annie: So, I decided I would wait out here for you.

Annie: I really didn't mean to eavesdrop, but the door wasn't closed.

Marguerite: It's fine, Annie. I don't mind. It wasn't anything confidential.

Marguerite: Professor Ludwig offered me a position at the Laplace Scientific Computing Center. If I were to accept, then yes, it would mean leaving.

Marguerite: Is there something you wanted to tell me?

For a moment, panic flashes across the girl's face.

Annie: Oh, is that all?

Annie: A placement at the LSCC really is an excellent opportunity. I've always been curious about how science could align with arcanum.

Annie: In any case, congratulations!

Marguerite: I haven't made up my mind yet.

Marguerite: If you are curious about arcanum technology, you should think about submitting an application too.

Annie: Oh, I-I don't think so.

Her face pales as she rushes to explain.

Annie: Not that I have anything against it, but I've never enjoyed the disorder that comes from arcanum.

Annie: Science is about complete, logical stories, not ambiguous, elusive concepts.

Annie: I decided a long time ago that I would put my trust in only what I could prove through scientific reason. That's the only way I feel safe.

Marguerite: An entirely reasonable human perspective. I'm sure they would appreciate someone with a traditional scientific viewpoint.

Annie: But I'm always so unsure, always second-guessing myself. I can't propose bold, creative hypotheses like real geniuses do.

Annie: I don't belong somewhere like Laplace.

Marguerite: I don't think that's a judgment you should make for yourself, Annie.

Marguerite: Oh, well, I shouldn't badger you. Wasn't there something you wanted to tell me?

Annie: No, it's nothing.

She awkwardly folds her hands behind her, concealing something.

It looks like a torn scrap of paper.

Annie: Just a trivial thing. Nothing important.

Annie: I didn't mean to bother you.

Marguerite: Please, Annie, what is it?

Marguerite: Did you want to show me something?

Annie: Just stop asking, Marguerite. I'm begging you.

The girl's plea leaves her unmoved.

Marguerite: Show me.

Marguerite: And what about you, Rachel?

Marguerite: You know, at this point, I don't think anyone at Laplace agrees with your hypothesis that the "Storm" can be explained through natural phenomena. It's quite remarkable that you persevere despite it all.

Rachel: Ha! Maybe so. But even if no one else agrees with me, does that mean it isn't true?

Rachel: After all, truth belongs in the hands of the brave few! So, why not me?

Rachel: I know many people at Laplace think I just refuse to admit natural science has lost its relevance in the face of the "Storm."

Rachel: I am stubborn, that much I admit.

Rachel: I chose this path, and I'll see it through to the end.

Marguerite: Even if it leaves you battered and bleeding?

Rachel: Even if it costs me everything.

The words hang for a heartbeat. Marguerite studies the depths of Rachel's pupils.

Marguerite: I see.

Marguerite: That's admirable. Truly.

[English text unavailable]

COL-313905

After finishing the installation of the elevated monitoring equipment, Coalwall returns to their temporary outpost.

Coalwall: Where's Rachel?

Marguerite: Taking temperature readings, she'll be gone for a while.

The reply elicits the precise reaction she had anticipated as Coalwall marches toward her with purpose.

Coalwall: I've deciphered the notebook.

Marguerite: I'm surprised it took you so long. Though you did make the mistake of asking for that fishbowl's help.

Marguerite: What did you find?

Coalwall: Initially, I focused on breaking down the equations in the notebook, searching for patterns concealed behind the figures.

Coalwall: And yes, I consulted with Mr. Ulrich. He suspected the entire notebook might be itself a kind of elaborate cipher.

Coalwall: But then I realized something on my own. Most of these equations were entirely ordinary, just things Annie must have copied down during lectures.

Coalwall: There was nothing remarkable about them at all, no ciphers or hidden secrets.

Coalwall takes a deep breath.

Marguerite: Go on. It seems like you've thought this through. I'd like to hear it.

Coalwall: Then I realized something.

Coalwall: All of these notes recorded Annie's entire academic life. From the equations alone, I could tell what classes she attended each day and what topics she was studying. It's clearer than any timetable.

Coalwall: It's also clear that at a certain point, her mental health began to deteriorate sharply.

Coalwall: Errors start cropping up in her calculations; the margins fill up with corrections. She wasn't able to concentrate on her studies.

Coalwall: Eventually, she made a significant computational error. I suspect that was one of the main reasons her research project fell through.

The suffering she once saw on paper now passes through her lips.

Coalwall: Something happened to her shortly before her accident. A change in her personality, she wasn't herself anymore.

Coalwall: The turning point was a day in late October. That was the day she wrote down your class schedule in her notebook.

Coalwall: She was trying to find a time to talk to you.

Coalwall: Marguerite, tell me honestly: what did you two talk about that day?!

Marguerite's expression is unchanged despite the frank accusation in Coalwall's tone.

Marguerite: After one of my classes in October, 1987?

Marguerite: So much time has passed. I can't recall anything specific.

Coalwall: I won't let you brush this off anymore!

Marguerite: No need to get upset. I'll answer whatever questions you have truthfully.

Marguerite: I did hear that, before Annie passed away, she was going through some difficulties.

Marguerite observes her colleague's growing frustration, the anger that tugs at every corner of her face. After allowing the silence to stretch, she speaks again with an unhurried pace.

Marguerite: I think I remember. Late October ...

Marguerite: I did see Annie around that time.

Marguerite: It was the day Ludwig offered me a position at Laplace. Annie overheard our conversation outside the office, and she reacted rather unusually.

Marguerite: I suppose it might have been around that time that she really started to withdraw.

Marguerite: She had no confidant, no mentor she could trust. As far as I could tell, she was quite lonely.

Marguerite: And eventually, that led to her "accident."

Coalwall: So, you're saying that, because you left, Annie ultimately chose to end her own life?

Coalwall: No. I can't believe that. I simply can't!

Coalwall: I may not have known her well, but everything I did know about her tells me she would never have done such a thing.

Despite the protests, she can read the doubt and heartbreak in her expression. She's on the backfoot.

Marguerite: Is it really so difficult to imagine? Maybe she wanted a release from all her troubles?

Coalwall: What?

Marguerite: Nothing. I was just speculating.

Marguerite: I simply didn't expect that you would arrive at that conclusion.

Coalwall: Oh, no. Don't you dare try to reverse this back to me. What are you implying?

But she can't read anything past her colleague's serene dead-eyed smile. Unsteady in her conviction, she suddenly feels the urge to withdraw.

Coalwall: Enough. I don't want to hear it.

Rachel: Everything's set up outside! The recorder should already be receiving data.

Rachel's excited voice cuts through the air, her hopeful energy arriving shortly before she does.

Rachel: Huh? Were you two arguing? Why does it feel colder in here than outside?

Marguerite: Not at all. Researcher Coalwall was feeling a little under-the-weather. I was concerned it might be related to the "Storm" countdown.

Coalwall: ...

Coalwall: I'm fine. I'm not showing any symptoms of Storm Syndrome.

Rachel: We have first-aid supplies on hand. If you feel unwell at all, tell me immediately.

Rachel: Wait! What's going on here?!

Marguerite turns toward the recorder at Rachel's side. It is receiving data transmitted from the deep-water probe.

Marguerite: That's a massive fluctuation for such a short interval.

Marguerite: What's happening outside?

Rachel pulls out a sheet of paper, rapidly converts the signal, and sketches a curve.

Rachel: Either the probe is malfunctioning, or we've just detected something extraordinary.

They consolidate the data, and Marguerite writes down a set of highly simplified equations.

Variables entered. Approximation computed. The result is unsettling.

Coalwall: This energy value ...

Coalwall: It resembles a global climatic phase transition.

Marguerite: It's difficult not to associate this with the "Storm."

Rachel: But the probe didn't complete its transmission. How is that possible?!

Marguerite: Perhaps the sudden shifts in temperature and depth caused the signal to stall.

Rachel: A worse possibility is that it never resurfaced at all.

Rachel: If that's the case, recovering the probe itself will be extremely difficult. Marguerite, you designed it. What's your assessment?

Marguerite: It shouldn't be so fragile that it can't withstand this level of fluctuation.

Rachel: S-So the probe itself could be trapped down there?

Coalwall: The last signal was at coordinate C023. We should try to recover it.

Rachel: I can't see the surface marker at C023. Coalwall, is the submersible hydrophone picking up anything?

Coalwall: No release signature or air bubbles detected.

Coalwall: The cable is fully taut. I pulled on it, and it didn't budge.

Coalwall: Do I have the right read here? Rachel, what's your assessment?

Rachel: The probe that detected the anomalous signal is stuck at a depth of thirty-six meters.

Marguerite: That's too deep for recovery.

Marguerite: Nonetheless, we've already gathered some extraordinary data. It should keep us occupied for quite some time.

Waves roll in under gathering shadows. No one sees Rachel's expression clearly.

She glances at her watch, then stares out toward the rolling sea.

Rachel: Researcher Coalwall, Marguerite.

Rachel: I'm going to dive down there and retrieve the probe.

[English text unavailable]

COL-313906

Temporary Station, Coral Islands

Coalwall: Have you lost your mind?!

Coalwall: You don't have the training for a deep dive like that! Besides, our suits aren't even rated for that depth!

Coalwall: There's no reason to risk your life over a probe!

Rachel: It's only a bit over twenty meters down!

Marguerite: Thirty-six meters ...

Rachel: This probe is of critical importance.

Rachel: It's the only instrument that recorded the anomaly. If we can't retrieve the physical unit, we may never get a second chance.

Coalwall: This was just our first field expedition with half-baked equipment. Everything is still in its infancy.

Coalwall: The recorder clearly captured all the transmitted data leading up to the anomaly. Even without recovering the probe, it will be enough.

Coalwall: Why are you trying to get yourself killed?

Rachel: Are you really that naive, Coalwall?

Rachel: We both know these remote readings are far too unreliable. If we can't retrieve the unit and calibrate it against the baseline probe, then all we have are isolated readings. They would laugh us out of headquarters.

Coalwall: But ...

She tries to interrupt, but Rachel, already pulling on her diving suit, continues speaking.

Rachel: Without verification, our analysis becomes a mere "hypothesis," or worse, imagination.

Rachel: Even Hardy and Ramanujan had to prove their conjectures.

Rachel: I must demonstrate ours beyond any dispute. Every rational doubt must be erased. I need tangible proof.

Marguerite: "Science is about complete, logical stories, not ambiguous, elusive concepts."

Rachel: Hah! That's exactly it!

Coalwall: This isn't the time for speeches!

Coalwall: The probe might simply be malfunctioning, and this expedition was rushed. We can wait until the next time.

Rachel: If we do, we might never encounter data like this again. It could be faulty or it could be real. That's precisely why I need to verify it.

Rachel's gaze softens. She looks at Marguerite.

Rachel: You understand me, don't you? Marguerite, I've waited long enough.

Her silence is like a mirror, and in it, Rachel seems to see her own conviction reflected.

Rachel: I have always lived my life for science.

Rachel: The history of science is filled with brilliant minds. The modern world is built upon that history. After centuries of ignorance, we finally separated myth from materialism.

Rachel: And then the "Storm" came, and everything reset to zero.

Coalwall: Rachel ...

Rachel lifts her head, looking out over the waves, making a final choice in her heart.

Rachel: All those geniuses, mathematicians, and physicists who dedicated their entire lives to discovering and defining the laws of the universe—what was all of it for?

Rachel: Plato, Hypatia, Galileo, Darwin ... Brilliant minds that struggled against ignorance for the sake of truth.

Rachel: My life, every human life, I can't let that all be washed away by the "Storm."

Rachel: I need to prove it still exists. I need to prove all of it.

Coalwall: I understand what you're saying, but you need to be alive to—

Rachel: Please stop, Researcher Coalwall. Respect my resolve as a scientist.

The words are sharp. There's no room for argument anymore.

Marguerite: You're certain you want to take this risk?

Rachel: Hah, yes. It's my choice. It feels like the first real choice I've made since the first "Storm."

Rachel: Call it fate, hah, or maybe call it "the deterministic ends of an uncaring universe." I don't care. It's my last chance to justify my life's work.

Marguerite: Then I won't stop you.

Coalwall: Wait. Wait!

A surge of anguish detonates in Coalwall's mind.

She recalls Annie's face swallowed by shadow, and the familiarity terrifies her.

Coalwall: Rachel, don't you think this is strange? The timing's too coincidental.

Coalwall: Data can be fabricated. Instruments are tamperable. All of this feels so unreal, like someone else was guiding you toward a specific end.

Rachel: What do you mean? Coalwall, are you questioning my scientific integrity?

Rachel: Or are you accusing Marguerite? Don't be ridiculous!

Rachel: I don't know what happened between the two of you back in Cambridge, but I don't have time for this here.

Rachel: It's easy to accuse without evidence!

Coalwall: No, I ...

Her tongue swells and trips. All she has is intuition, not evidence.

Coalwall: I mean that we all know how desperate you are to show science alone is capable of explaining the "Storm," and now this opportunity—it feels too good to be true, too perfect.

Rachel: Enough.

Rachel: I appreciate your concern, but my decision is made.

Rachel: There's nothing more to say. I'm going to retrieve the probe.

Marguerite: ...

Equatorial Coral Islands

Rachel: Marguerite.

Marguerite quickens her pace to catch up. Dusk is falling as they walk side by side along the shore.

There is no trace of the "Storm" in the sea breeze yet, only the stillness of nature.

Marguerite: Hey.

Rachel: That paper, *Samplings of Global and Regional Chaotic Energy Route Changes*, you wrote it, didn't you?

Marguerite stops walking. They hold each other's gaze for a brief moment.

Rachel: It had to be you. Only someone with a rare genius could have made those calculations. I wonder if anyone else in the world could have figured it out. No one would have expected you of all people.

Rachel: But I saw it. Your statistical habits are identical—small patterns in the way you structure data. It's a pity I never asked you to co-author with me. I might've noticed sooner.

Rachel: Lorentz Butterfly is a beautiful pseudonym. I admire the symbolism.

Lorentz Butterfly: ...

The pale researcher's face changes to something rarely seen.

She offers a genuine smile.

Lorentz Butterfly: In truth, I believe neither science nor technology can unravel the secrets of the "Storm."

Lorentz Butterfly: I wouldn't have been much of a co-author. Our ideals stand in direct opposition.

Rachel: I see. And now I realize why that component didn't fit right earlier. I assume you modified our probe to fit your own ends.

Rachel: So, Lorentz Butterfly, what did you do to it?

Lorentz Butterfly: Nothing substantial. I've only added a module designed to monitor Chaotic Energy.

Lorentz Butterfly: But there is something else. You know that under our new safety regulations, we have to leave at least ninety minutes before the "Storm." That was our compromise.

Rachel: Hah. So that's why it didn't surface.

Rachel: Recovering it too early would compromise your observation, just as leaving it down there would compromise mine.

Lorentz Butterfly: Bring it back at the right time, and you'll have my thanks.

Rachel: You mean at the very last moment before the "Storm" sweeps us all away.

Rachel: Now I'm curious. What could possibly keep me down there for so long? What else did you leave down there?

Lorentz Butterfly: Don't worry. I've ensured you'll have sufficient oxygen.

Rachel: You'd better add me as co-author on your next paper.

The words don't land right. Too bitter for a joke, too genuine for a barb.

Lorentz Butterfly: I'm afraid your contribution wouldn't warrant co-authorship, Rachel.

Rachel: I'd like to think wagering my life might earn a footnote at least.

Rachel: But it doesn't matter now, Marguerite. Countless times, you stood firmly, unconditionally, by my side. Now I'll do the same for you.

Rachel: Farewell, dear Marguerite.

Her path lies before her. She refuses to wait another second.

[English text unavailable]

COL-313907

A severed rope lies wet at the center of the table.

It once tethered Rachel's diving suit.

Coalwall's every suspicion proven true, and now she sits on a desolate island with the accused.

Coalwall: I don't understand why she did it. It was suicide.

Marguerite looks over to her without expression.

Marguerite: She was prepared to sacrifice herself for her research.

Marguerite: In this era where the "Storm" has stripped science of its meaning, it was her last stand for reason over chaos.

Marguerite: Why would you think of stopping her?

Coalwall: If she dies because of this, it'll be the end of everything.

Coalwall: No future. No possibility. Nothing.

Coalwall: Was Annie's "accident" like this as well?

Marguerite: Does it matter? Would you want to hear the answer, even if it might destroy you?

Coalwall: Of course.

Coalwall: This isn't the first time you've implied there's more to her accident. Speak plainly.

Marguerite: Have I made any implications? Or have you just been trying to read suspicion into my answers?

Marguerite: You want Annie's death to be something other than an accident. You want a culprit to hold responsible.

Marguerite: When it comes to Annie, you've never asked me for the truth.

Coalwall: ...

Coalwall clenches her fists.

Marguerite: Oh! Forgive me. I've finally remembered what else happened that day.

Marguerite: That day in late October, 1987. The day Annie came to see me. The "turning point," as you call it.

She pauses, smiling, waiting for Coalwall to ask.

Coalwall: What happened?

She lets the question hang in the air, then, as if to toy with her, answers with a question of her own.

Marguerite: Do you remember how I correctly predicted that you were coming to Laplace?

Coalwall: You said you saw the dispatch list on Simone's desk. My designation was on it.

Coalwall: And I'd used that alias to publish a few pieces in the Cambridge student papers.

Marguerite: Your memory serves you well.

Marguerite: Maybe you remember all the trouble Annie had after those scandals involving her family's business became public?

Marguerite: She said her parents' business dealings were just the beginning. They were walking on thin ice with the law and with the tabloids.

Marguerite: She wouldn't dare comment on anything political at school or even the slightest bit controversial. So, she stayed quiet—anything—to stay under the radar.

Marguerite: Now that I think about it, that month must have been a significant time for you as well.

Marguerite: I recall that was the first time the name "Coalwall" appeared in the campus papers.

1987.

Annie: Just stop asking, Marguerite. I'm begging you.

She pleads, but the girl before her, her only friend, remains unmoved, pressing her to expose the wound instead.

Marguerite: Show me.

Marguerite: What did you bring me?

With barely any effort, Marguerite snatches the scrap from her hands.

In the struggle, the paper is torn into pieces and scatters across the floor.

A corner of the latest student newspaper.

Marguerite: "I remember the hunger and the cold. I remember the coal dust on my father's hands."

Marguerite: "I remember my mother's sobbing cries when news of my father's death came. I remember the rage that crushed me into the earth with the weight of a mountain."

Marguerite: Oh. A piece written by a student from a mining family. Both her parents passed away two years ago.

Marguerite: That name, how fitting, like a wall of coal rising from the excavation pit, faintly luminous in the dark.

Marguerite: Annie, would you care to explain what's going on?

The girl before her shivers fearfully, her hands trembling at her side.

Annie: People think I'm just as responsible for their deaths as my father. They think of me as a monster, or at best as a child of monsters.

Annie: I don't blame Coalwall. It's been like this since people found out about them. I've been painted with the same brush. They look at me and see a spoiled brat given everything by the worst kind of dirty, dangerous, and exploitative industry.

Marguerite: All this article did was give them an excuse to unleash their hatred. It doesn't change anything.

Annie: I-I don't know what to do. Marguerite, I'm not sure I blame them. But I didn't choose my family any more than they chose theirs. No one chooses their circumstances.

Annie: I saw Coalwall today; I don't think she even noticed me as I walked by.

Annie: Seeing her, knowing what she's been through, I don't feel like I deserve anything that I have here.

Annie: I can't look at her without feeling like I was the one who let her father die and killed her mother with all that grief and pain.

Annie: She had to fight for a full scholarship, just for a chance to stand on equal footing with me.

Annie: So maybe I deserve all of that scorn. Maybe that's just what I get for benefiting from her pain.

Her trembling hands slow with exhaustion.

Annie: I'm sorry, Marguerite. I shouldn't have troubled you with any of this. You must think I'm being ridiculous.

Annie: I ... I should go.

Annie: I should never have bothered you in the first place.

She turns and slinks away, looking as pale as a phantom.

Night has fallen as their evacuation timer continues to tick down.

In their tiny outpost, Coalwall reels back, inadvertently knocking over a chair.

Marguerite: I never spoke to her after that day.

Marguerite: I suppose I did take notice of her change in behavior, but I didn't see how it concerned me. She never reached out to me at any rate.

Marguerite: Annie, Annie. She was sweet, really. Probably too sensitive but kind.

Marguerite: Then a few weeks later, there was that theft in the lab building—sensitive medical compounds, among them, the kind necessary to induce cardiac arrest.

Marguerite: Who can say? It may only have been a coincidence.

Coalwall: I ...

Coalwall struggles, suddenly feeling choked with some unrealized emotion.

Coalwall: I never meant to make her feel that way. I was bitter, of course, but I never blamed her for what happened.

Coalwall: I just didn't want people to forget what happened to my parents.

Coalwall: Was it me? Did I cause Annie's death?

Coalwall: No conspiracy. No hidden manipulation. Just ... me ...

The other woman shrugs.

Marguerite: You were so unsettled by the idea that her death was an accident.

Marguerite: Strange. All this time, you've thought I must be guilty in some way.

Marguerite: But it's never one thread that pulls the noose. Everything is connected; every word, every action shapes the next, like the flapping of a butterfly's wings.

Marguerite: But Annie said it well: no one chooses their circumstances. You couldn't have known that penning a touching memorial to your family would light the fuse that led to her demise.

Marguerite: But then, perhaps on some subconscious level, you sensed there was more. That unease you felt led you to look for a culprit.

Marguerite: To Annie's only "friend," a reclusive transfer student with an unclear past and habit of writing strange equations on blackboards.

Coalwall: It was my indifference that allowed all of this to happen.

Coalwall: Because I let them torture her for something she couldn't change.

Coalwall: But that still doesn't explain everything. That equation you wrote, I swear it was modeling Annie's behavior. That's why I suspected you.

A chill spreads through her body.

Coalwall: Wait, that equation, you wrote it for me to see, didn't you?

Coalwall: Right down to my first day at Laplace. You predicted all of this, didn't you?

Coalwall: So, what the hell is this? You let me think I was acting on my conscience, that I was searching for the truth, and all the while I was just acting out a formula you had already solved.

Coalwall: A study of human behavior and decision-making, but I wasn't even the data. I was the proof, a walking replication.

Coalwall: But why? Why would you do this?

Coalwall: And what about Rachel? What role did she serve in this sick formula of yours?

Marguerite: I encourage you to solve that for yourself. The answer is quite simple, but I would hate to interrupt your process.

Confusion. Disbelief. Incomprehension.

But she excels at solving problems and eliminating impossibilities.

Coalwall: Setting aside the risk Rachel faced and all the elaborate staging, your ultimate goal was to delay the probe's retrieval.

Coalwall: You let her go out there just to make sure you got reliable data.

Her conclusion defies all reason, yet it seems to be true.

Coalwall: So, all of this, all of it was to prove your theories about the "Storm"?

She lets Coalwall study her face without an answer.

And in return, she reads from her an unprecedented mixture of danger and exhilaration.

Lorentz Butterfly: You seem upset by this outcome. Allow me to offer a remedy.

Lorentz Butterfly: This is our teleport disk, the only means we have of returning safely to Laplace.

Lorentz Butterfly: Why would I give you it? Can you figure out my motive? I trust you can.

Lorentz Butterfly: The decision is yours.

Lorentz Butterfly: Leave me here to face the "Storm." In this one moment, you have the chance to bypass society, morality, and the law. Pass judgment as you see fit.

Lorentz Butterfly: Or allow me to return safely to Laplace with you and see whether your hypothesis is correct.

Coalwall: You're completely insane.

Coalwall: A monster impossible to comprehend.

Lorentz Butterfly: Well? What will you do?

[English text unavailable]

COL-313908

The "Storm" descends once more, eroding the remnants of 1987.

Hallway, Laplace

Inside the Laplace Scientific Computing Center, some researchers pause their work and stare at the absurd, distorted world outside. Others move faster, seizing this rare window to conduct experiments.

Marguerite: ...

Marguerite: The "Storm."

She casts a detached glance at the others and continues, not once breaking her stride.

"Unnecessary Information" Room

Only a few weeks have passed since she joined Laplace. She's still considered a newcomer.

But recently, something has changed. She uncovered a secret hidden within Laplace.

Marguerite: Here it is, archives related to Chaos Theory. The contents are riddled with errors, almost comically deliberate and unlikely to draw anyone's attention.

Marguerite: Yet why hide an elegant riddle here? It stands in stark contrast to this file's mediocrity.

Marguerite: Who could possibly decipher such a riddle, especially without any real grounding in Chaos Theory?

Only someone utterly bored with everything Laplace has to offer.

It does not take her long to filter out the interference and reach the answer.

Marguerite: Are these coordinates?

She invokes an arcane skill, attempting to contact a faraway place.

Marguerite: Whispered words, speak!

The first thing to emerge from the other end is a fragrance steeped in the scent of tears.

???: Oh! So someone found the coordinates at last.

???: You're the very first to decipher the puzzle I concealed within Laplace.

Marguerite: It wasn't much of a challenge.

???: Hah! Perhaps so, but once you consider the surrounding challenges, it becomes significantly more difficult.

???: For instance, it was hidden in a neglected file, one riddled with errors and liable to deletion at any time, and Chaos Theory stands in direct opposition to Laplace's doctrine.

Marguerite: So? Who exactly are you, madam?

???: My name and identity are irrelevant. I have lived a very long time, and such labels no longer matter to me.

???: I am no longer within the Laplace Scientific Computing Center, nor am I under the Foundation's jurisdiction.

???: I left those coordinates to invite you into a secret society hidden within Laplace—Institutum Lorentz.

???: Tell me, dear, would you like to find the very first butterfly that caused the "Storm" to fall?

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

The "Storm" and the first circulation observation end abruptly.

Beyond the ICU doors, Coalwall and Ulrich stand vigil over a sleeping figure.

Coalwall: Will she recover?

Ulrich: I'm afraid I have no more insight on that account than you do.

Ulrich: The medical personnel have relayed to me that Rachel was suffering from severe oxygen toxicity, resulting in severe respiratory distress and retinal damage. She hasn't been responsive to any attempt to wake her. In short, she's in a coma.

Ulrich: Her monitoring equipment indicates that during the probe's recovery, she experienced some kind of unforeseen underwater accident.

Ulrich: Something severed the instrument's cable, causing it to float several hundred meters away from its original coordinates. It greatly delayed our recovery time. There's no explaining how. We might as well conclude a shark decided to take it as a chew toy.

Ulrich: The truth of the matter will have to wait until she regains consciousness.

Coalwall: ...

Ulrich: She is also exhibiting mild symptoms of Storm Syndrome. Fortunately, the observation point was far from the epicenter of the "Storm," though thankfully her distance from the epicenter greatly reduced its effects. She handled it well.

Coalwall: Fortunate indeed.

Coalwall: Perhaps that, too, was part of the design.

The ferrofluid does not grasp her meaning.

Ulrich: This kind of work is simply unsuitable to fragile humans.

Coalwall: Mr. Ulrich, I would not wish for even you, an Awakened, to violate protocol by returning to safety at the very last moment before the "Storm" falls.

Coalwall: All for a single set of data.

The ferrofluid rests placidly at the center of his helmet.

Ulrich: But there are certain dangerous tasks we have no choice but to undertake, and we Awakened are simply better equipped.

Ulrich: Let's hope Researcher Rachel wakes up soon. Otherwise, our natural physics department may be reduced to just Adler. One may as well just declare the whole thing defunct.

Ulrich: Now then, I'm off to read Lorentz Butterfly's latest paper.

Ulrich: She's calculated several coordinates where supernatural phenomena may occur, suggesting a connection to the core mechanism of the "Storm."

Ulrich: Though I really do wonder how these provocative letters always manage to bypass security and end up on my desk.

Coalwall: Supernatural phenomena. That is indeed a compelling direction.

Ulrich turns toward her in a sideways glance.

Ulrich: You surprise me, Coalwall; I thought you had little interest in exploring arcanum theory.

Coalwall: Ah, well, I've simply come to understand something.

Coalwall: Her true objective is surprisingly simple.

The words bounce off of his glass exterior without understanding.

Ulrich: Who do you mean? Lorentz Butterfly?

Coalwall: Forget it.

Coalwall: Mr. Ulrich, if I had no interest in arcanum theory whatsoever, I would never have joined Laplace.

Coalwall: After all, the "Storm" is unquestionably an arcane phenomenon.

Coalwall: But I don't believe science has become obsolete in the face of that fact. The rules of the universe have simply changed beyond recognition.

Coalwall: It's time for science to embark on a new path.

Ulrich: By integrating arcanum?

Coalwall: Exactly.

Ulrich: In that much we are agreed. At Laplace, most consider Institutum Lorentz an affront to science. I, however, remain undecided.

Ulrich: As Lorentz Butterfly wrote in her letter:

Lorentz Butterfly: **Only through pneuma can we understand Chaotic Energy. Only by monitoring the ebb and flow of Chaotic Energy can we "measure" the "Storm."**

Ulrich: I don't entirely understand her methodology, but it may yet reveal the truth of our world.

Ulrich: Hmm. I'm curious about this Lorentz Butterfly. What sort of person do you think she is?

Coalwall gazes at her sleeping companion beyond the glass in quiet contemplation.

Coalwall: A genius, one unconstrained by rules, norms, maybe even basic manners. But a genius—that much no one can deny.